Drawing from the Odisha, AP and Telangana policies, the onus on providing information pertaining to other Maoist members, source of finance, arms and ammunition would be on the surrendered operative. A state-level committee will conduct the screening and decide whether the surrender should be accepted or not but unlike, say, in Odisha, there will be no grading of operatives.

The draft policy in MP is focused more on the rehabilitation of Maoist operatives who turn themselves in. It provides Rs 6,000 a month for three months for skill upgradation and a house under the PM Awas Yojana. The rehabilitation policy also gives Rs 2,000 per month for 36 months in case the operative wishes to study, free foodgrains under the National Food Security Act, health insurance and employment as a *gopniya sainik*, a temporary job helping in intelligence gathering. In case the surrendered operative helps in liquidation/ arrest of other operatives, he/ she may be appointed as a full-time police constable. Interestingly, it also provides Rs 25,000 for the marriage of surrendering Maoists if they are single at the time.

Amnesty for past crimes—a contentious issue in all surrender policies—has also been dealt with. The screening committee will have powers to recommend withdrawal of cases for past crimes. However, since the law does not provide for amnesty in cases of serious offence, the usual practice is to not file the *challan* (chargesheet) in court for such offences. "This also helps the state keep control over the surrendered operative who may be under pressure to go back to crime," says a top MP police official. The draft policy also contains provisions for allocation of farm land, jobs and cash compensation for those who have been killed in Maoist violence. Incidentally, MP now has only three districts that are officially Maoist-affected—Mandla, Dindori and Balaghat.

India's counterinsurgency strategies have dwelt heavily on surrender and rehabilitation policies but they were rationalised and streamlined only after the national policy of 2014. Maoist-affected states have had mixed experience in executing surrender policies. MP's neighbour Chhattisgarh, where the spread and impact of Maoism has been far greater, had numerous stories of corruption and fake surrenders in the initial days of its policy.



PRIZE CATCH Maoist leader Diwakar and wife in custody in Chhattisgarh

Chhattisgarh announced its first surrender and rehabilitation policy in 2004 but it did not find many takers. Between 2004 and 2014, when the second policy was announced by the state, there were only a hundred or so surrenders. Questions were raised even then about sham surrenders and security personnel forcing foot soldiers to give up, without getting to any of the top brass. After the second policy, in 2016, some 1,160 alleged Maoists surrendered, but the central government's screening committee ruled that over 1,000 of them did not qualify as Maoists. A year earlier, the state government's screening committee too had found 75 per cent of the surrendered Maoists "ineligible" for the rehabilitation package.

Maoist- affected states have had mixed results with surrender policies; Andhra saw success, Chhattisgarh not so much

Andhra Pradesh, on the other hand, has had a far more successful surrender and rehabilitation policy, first introduced in 1993 and continuously upgraded thereafter. Between 2005 and 2015, Maoist-related offences in Andhra Pradesh dropped from 500 to two. The state's anti-Naxal Greyhound force took credit for this, but police officers in MP say the rehabilitation measures were equally responsible for it. The 'rehab programme' was focused on rural areas through the remote and internal areas development (RAID) scheme. Analysts believe the measures damaged the Maoists' search for new recruits.

But does a surrender and rehabilitation policy suggest a weakening of efforts on the operational side? "Not at all," says Sajid Farid Shapu, the Madhya Pradesh IG for Naxal operations. "The success of the Andhra model in tackling Maoism suggests that surrenders are directly proportional to the amount of pressure applied on Maoists through operations. There should be no let-up on that front. In fact, the success of the surrender policy depends a great deal on operational successes." MP is also setting up an all-tribal force to counter Maoism in their areas. It already has a dedicated armed force, 'the Hawk', deployed in eastern MP for the purpose. ■